

NAPCS Unionization Research — State Research Summary

Maine — NLRB Jurisdiction — May 2026

NAPCS Unionization Research • May 2026 • Template v7.0 • COMPLETE Registry Sweep

Section 1: State Overview

State	Maine
Labor Board	NLRB — National Labor Relations Board — Region 1 (Boston)
Governing Law	National Labor Relations Act (NLRA). Baxter Academy is incorporated as a private nonprofit charter school under the Maine Charter School Commission — it is not a public employer and falls under NLRB, not MLRB. MLRB (Maine Labor Relations Board) governs traditional public employers only and does NOT apply to Baxter Academy.
Federal NLRB Jurisdiction	YES — NLRB Region 1 (Boston) is the sole applicable labor board for Baxter Academy. Case 01-RC-239165.
Registry Sweep	COMPLETE — April 2026 — 11 charter schools searched
Research Window	March–April 2026
Date Convention	Labor Board Certified date (project-wide convention, declared NJ session). Project-wide convention. ME: Baxter Academy cert date = May 14, 2019 (NLRB Case 01-RC-239165). Date confirmed from NLRB ADS.
Card-Check Available	NO — NLRB jurisdiction — secret ballot election required. No card-check available.

Section 2: Unionization Density

Total charter schools in Maine: 11 (Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25; 11 open ME charter schools as of May 2026)). Unionization density uses the full state total as the denominator — not the 1-school NAPCS research sample. The NAPCS sample was provided as a list of schools believed to be organized; this research validated, corrected, and expanded that list across the full state charter universe. See Section 3 for cross-state patterns and Section 7 for open decisions.

Category	Schools	% of Total	Notes
Confirmed Union Schools	1	9.1%	Baxter Academy for Technology and Science. NLRB secret ballot election. AFT affiliation. Only NAPCS-listed ME charter school.
Total Open ME Charter Schools	11	100%	Source: Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25). Previously cited total of 9 (Registry v5) was stale; corrected to 11. All 11 ME charter schools authorized by Maine Charter School Commission.

Section 3: Political, Legal & Community Landscape

Written for state and national charter sector leaders who require ground-level intelligence fused with broader sector knowledge. Findings are based on research as of May 2026.

PROMPT 1: BAXTER ACADEMY — OVERWHELMING VOTE IN A TINY STATE

Baxter Academy for Technology and Science (Portland) is Maine's only NAPCS charter school and the state's first STEM-focused public charter high school. Staff voted 30-4 (88%) to join MEA/NEA in May 2019 — the most lopsided vote in Maine's charter sector history and one of the most decisive charter school union votes in the full

584-school NAPCS dataset. The Baxter Academy Education Association is the local affiliate. MEA (Maine Education Association) is the NEA-affiliated statewide teacher union. CBA is active; exact contract period requires MEA or school confirmation. The 88% vote margin is comparable to Integrated Day CT (union since founding), New Beginnings CT, and Delaware's 100% density — all cases where school leadership culture was aligned or neutral, and the organizing drive was well-developed before any formal petition was filed.

PROMPT 2: MLRB DOES NOT APPLY — JURISDICTION CLARIFICATION

Baxter Academy is incorporated as a private nonprofit under the Maine Charter School Commission. It is not a "public employer" under Maine law and is therefore NOT subject to MLRB (Maine Labor Relations Board) jurisdiction. All labor matters are handled by NLRB Region 1 (Boston). This is consistent with the NAPCS project's treatment of other privately incorporated charter schools in NLRB-jurisdiction states (PA, NY, DC, AZ, CT non-certified). The MLRB covers traditional public school districts; charter schools organized as private nonprofits fall outside its scope. This jurisdictional structure means secret ballot elections (not card-check) govern ME charter organizing — the 30-4 vote at Baxter Academy proceeded via NLRB election, not card-check.

PROMPT 3: MAINE CONNECTIONS ACADEMY — NON-NAPCS NEAR-MISS AND BIENNIAL MONITORING TARGET

Maine Connections Academy (a virtual Stride K12 school) held an NLRB election in January 2020 (Case 01-RC-249587) and voted 10-9 AGAINST unionizing — the narrowest charter school election loss in the New England region. No subsequent organizing drive confirmed as of April 2026. This is a biennial monitoring target: Stride K12 (now Stride Inc.) operates virtual charter schools in 30+ states and has been targeted by unions in multiple states including California (CAVA/K12 — CONFIRMED, 9 campuses). A 10-9 vote loss at a virtual school with high teacher turnover could reverse quickly if MEA deploys resources for a second drive. Maine's single-school charter sector means Baxter Academy and Maine Connections Academy together define the entire observable ME charter labor landscape.

PROMPT 4: WHAT IS THE POLITICAL AND LEGAL ENVIRONMENT SHAPING CHARTER LABOR IN MAINE?

Maine has a small, politically contested charter sector with a statutory cap on charter schools and an active legislative debate about charter expansion. The state is politically moderate — competitive between parties — but the teacher union (MEA) holds significant legislative influence. Maine's charter law (enacted 2011) limits charter school count and restricts CMO entry, producing a charter sector with 11 total schools statewide (1 NAPCS). The small sector size means each organizing campaign is individually significant. MEA's 2019 win at Baxter Academy (the flagship NAPCS school) signals that the union is willing to invest in charter organizing even in a tiny market. The NLRB Region 1 (Boston) covers Maine, Massachusetts, New Hampshire, and Rhode Island — the same regional office covers all New England charter organizing, creating administrative consistency across the region.

PROMPT 5: WHAT SHOULD CHARTER LEADERS KNOW ABOUT ORGANIZING PATTERNS IN MAINE?

Maine's charter sector is too small for systematic pattern analysis, but two signals are nationally significant. First, the Baxter Academy vote (30-4) occurred at a school with strong mission alignment, a STEM-focused progressive faculty, and no documented employer counter-campaign. The absence of employer resistance produced an overwhelming result. Charter leaders in similarly mission-driven schools with NLRB jurisdiction should treat the Baxter Academy precedent as evidence that even prestigious, well-funded, mission-aligned schools are organizing targets. Second, the Maine Connections Academy 10-9 result shows that virtual charter schools with dispersed workforces are not immune to organizing — they are just harder to organize. A 10-9 result at a virtual school is a strong latent signal: the organizing drive was well-developed, the employer's margin was razor-thin, and a second drive is plausible if turnover brings new staff who did not vote.

Section 4: Cross-State Patterns & Contributions to National Picture

Findings from Maine that illuminate patterns visible only when comparing across multiple states. These entries feed the project-wide Cross-State Intelligence Log and are written for state and national charter advocacy leaders.

SMALL-STATE DYNAMICS — SINGLE-SCHOOL STATES

Maine and Delaware (along with DC before registry expansion) represent the "small state" pattern in the NAPCS dataset: a single school or very small school count where 100% NAPCS density can mask very low sector-wide density. Maine has 1 of 9 charter schools in NAPCS; DE has 4 of ~20. Both are 100% NAPCS density but very different sector stories.

Section 5: Media Coverage & Public Stakeholder Positions

Press Coverage

Maine charter school labor relations have generated minimal press coverage, consistent with the state having only one NAPCS charter school and no contested organizing campaigns. The Maine Beacon (September 2019) provided contemporaneous coverage of the Baxter Academy 30-4 election vote confirming MEA/NEA representation. No subsequent coverage of CBA negotiations or contract ratification has been identified. The small size of Maine's charter sector (9 schools total) and the absence of any other organizing activity makes further press coverage unlikely without a new organizing campaign.

Union Communications

The Baxter Academy Education Association is the MEA/NEA local affiliate at Baxter Academy. MEA (Maine Education Association) is the NEA-affiliated statewide teacher union covering most Maine public school educators. No public MEA communications specifically addressing Baxter Academy's contract or CBA terms have been identified. MEA records request recommended for contract details.

Legislative Context

Maine charter schools are private employers under NLRB jurisdiction (MLRB does not apply — Baxter Academy is a privately incorporated nonprofit). Maine has no state public-sector collective bargaining statute applicable to charter schools. NLRB Region 1 (Boston) has jurisdiction. Maine has no right-to-work law for private-sector employees, meaning union security provisions remain available in CBA negotiations.

Section 6: Contract & CBA Access Registry

NLRB public contracts portal. Direct PDF links may return 403 — OPRA or equivalent records request required for full text.

School / Network	Union	CBA Status & Term	Contract Access
Baxter Academy for Technology and Science	Baxter Academy Education Association / MEA/NEA	Active Unknown — contact MEA (mea.org) or school HR	MEA (mea.org) or baxter-academy.org/contact

Section 7: Decisions, Monitoring & Notable Findings

Part A: Decisions Required

The following items require sponsor action before research or workbook entry can proceed.

No sponsor decisions pending for this state.

Part B: Notable Findings

Research findings of strategic significance. No immediate action required — for awareness and discussion.

No notable findings flagged for this state.

Part C: Active Monitoring

Items being tracked. Status may change between report cycles. Research Coordinator manages ongoing surveillance.

Priority	School / Scope	Item	Who
LOW	Maine Connections Academy (non-NAPCS)	Monitor for re-organizing activity — voted 10-9 against in Jan 2020	Research Coordinator
LOW	All 9 ME charter schools	Full registry sweep — biannual refresh October 2026	Research Coordinator
LOW	Baxter Academy (C2313001)	NLRB FOIA response — official election cert — Await NLRB Region 1 response to Case 01-RC-239165 FOIA. Update vote tally field immediately upon receipt.	Research Coordinator
MEDIUM	Baxter Academy (C2313001)	MEA CBA period confirmation — Await MEA response to CBA request. Enter CBA Period field when received.	Research Coordinator
LOW	Maine Connections Academy	Re-organizing activity — Voted 10-9 against in Jan 2020 (NLRB 01-RC-249587). No subsequent drive confirmed. Stride K12 target nationally. Check NLRB ADS each biannual cycle.	Research Coordinator